unequal pre-Independence past, but accept that granting benefits on the basis of caste is unavoidable. As for ourselves, as intellectual heirs of an anti-colonial freedom movement that explicitly rejected caste, and outlawed caste discrimination, we aren't supposed to admit to caste feeling even if, in some cases, it lurks somewhere beneath the surface.

I am conscious of my own bias in the opposite direction; as the son of a newspaper executive from Kerala who dropped his caste name (Nair) at college in response to Mahatma Gandhi's exhortations to do so, moved to London and brought his children up in Westernised Bombay, I am a product of a nationalist generation that was consciously raised to be oblivious of caste.

I still remember my own discovery of caste. I was an eleven-year-old representing the seventh form in an inter-class theatrical event at which the eighth form sketch featured the scion of a famous Bollywood dynasty (who are Hindu). The boy would later become a successful screen heart-throb. I had acted, penned a humorous poem and organised my class's efforts, and the young man was either intrigued or disconcerted by what he had witnessed, for he sought me out the next morning at school.

'Tharoor,' he asked me at the head of the steps near the toilet, 'what caste are you?'

I blinked my nervousness at the Great Man. 'I—I don't know,' I stammered. My father, who never mentioned anyone's religion, let alone caste, had not bothered to enlighten me on such matters. 'You don't know?' the actor's son demanded in astonishment. 'What do you mean, you don't know? Everybody knows their own caste.'

I shamefacedly confessed I didn't.

'You mean you're not a Brahmin or something?'

I couldn't even avow I was a something. The Great Man never spoke to me again in school. But I went home that evening and extracted an explanation from my parents, whose eclectic liberality had left me in such ignorance. They told me, in simplified terms, about the Nairs; and so it is to that schoolboy, celluloid hero of the future, that I owe my first lesson about my genealogical past.

Despite this enforced awareness, I grew up thinking of caste as an irrelevance. The idea of caste as a badge of identity bothered me hardly